

increased tremendously. When the teachers let the kids out to play, some would huddle close to the buildings for fear of the cars; the others were continually having to be warned to stay away from the highway. At last the principal of the kindergarten had a six-foot, chain-link fence installed around the play yard. The next day when the children went out for recess, they played right up against the fence. The fence restricted their freedom, but it also provided a safe boundary that allowed them the maximum limits of their playground.

Money should be used the same way. Discipline yourself with regards to money, and you'll find that it does not restrict your freedom. It allows you to expand to the full measure of what God wants you to have.

The minimum discipline in the area of money is called a budget. A budget answers the questions, "Where is my money coming from this month, and where is my money going this month?" That's all a budget can do. Everyone, especially young couples, needs a budget. A budget has to be detailed enough that it will help you manage money, but not so detailed that it feels oppressive. I'll be discussing budgets extensively in the next four chapters.

9 A WORKABLE BUDGET

The term *budget* has unjustly earned a bad reputation. Without fear of contradiction, I can say that ANYONE who does not live on a budget is not handling his finances efficiently, especially those people who think they don't need one. It's better to live on a budget and know where your money is going every month than to live without one and not know. A good budget does not restrict your freedom. It merely tells you when you have spent what you have agreed you can spend.

WHO NEEDS A BUDGET?

Most of the women I have ever counseled have said initially, "Oh, I know what a budget is. It's a plan where the husband